Even during meetings when Goa would push his nose against the glass door adjacent to Ratan's room to go out to the balcony, the eighty-odd-year-old would excuse himself, making haste to open the door.

Embarrassing Humility

Ratan is disarmingly polite and embarrassingly correct. He has carried on a tradition that the Tatas represent, though ironically his surname can also mean a 'nickname denoting a "hot-tempered"' personality. He gives every person their dignity and never fails to acknowledge the importance of everyone's work, however small a job they may be doing.

Ishaat Hussain says that Ratan's humility is so humbling that he has to often resist the urge to tell those who are boastful and arrogant to learn from the Tatas. 'When I see other people, who have one hundredth of his stature and the way they strut around the place, I feel like telling them, go take a lesson from Ratan Tata or JRD. Whatever happens, no stigma will ever get attached to them as they are so perfect.' Even those outside the group are amazed at Ratan's 'deep sense of humility despite being such a tall business leader', as Sunil Bharti Mittal puts it.

A meeting with Ratan, especially for the first time, can be an extremely humbling experience. Soft-spoken to the point of being almost inaudible, the gentle giant is so polite and perfect in his manners that it can embarrass those who are accustomed to rudeness from famous personalities. One could come away from a meeting with him with an overwhelming sense of inadequacy. There is perhaps no one amongst the many scores of people interviewed for this book, who has not marvelled at his simplicity and humility. Syamal Gupta says that he is amazed by Ratan's humility; JRD was also very humble, but could be vociferous at times, he says. Ratan is different; he never raises his voice.

Rafael Reif, president of MIT, says, 'Ratan himself has always been for me the perfect embodiment of humility', and at 'MIT, our tradition has been to take humility as a fundamental approach to life, without being conscious of it'. This 'instantly created an additional bond of kinship between us', he adds.

Ratan will even treat politely those he considers to not have been fair to him. The manner in which he dealt with Russi Mody after the former TISCO chairman's retirement is an exemplar. Even after resigning from